

SHAME EL-SHEIKH

The prime minister's total surrender in Sharm el-Sheikh or allowing Washington to be the arbiter of India's nuclear independence shows the extent to which the Government will compromise on national interest

By S. Prasannarajan

Maybe the text that has brought India to its now-familiar national position—prostration—at Sharm el-Sheikh has something to do with the context, geographical as well as historical. The city on the Red Sea, any decent tourist guide on Egypt will tell you, is the ideal destination for divers and windsurfers. The worthies who assembled at the resort in the Sinai Peninsula may not be known for their deep sea diving skills, but as leaders of the Non-Aligned Movement—Ah, NAM, the grossest irrelevancy in geopolitics—they are masters in the political equivalent of windsurfing. Ideally, the prime minister of 21st century India should not have been there at all, for NAM is a bad joke. The vintage postcolonial romance of Nehru, Tito and Nasser outlived its use

long ago, if it ever had any use. Today, the original catchwords like imperialism and colonialism, or for that matter the holy doctrine of neutrality, serve only the rhetorical purpose of desperate Third Worldists. NAM is the most elastic club of tin-pot potentates and cannibalistic dictators from Africa and elsewhere, and it is one movement that has turned the legitimacy of colonial struggle into a licence for dictatorships. Isn't NAM a misplaced cause for India? Or is it that our prime minister, in his quest for statesmanship, will go to any doomed archival site of international brotherhood as the last salesman of peace from the Orient?

Now we all know that Manmohan Singh at Sharm el-Sheikh has sold off more than the bargainer from Pakistan has demanded from him. Why? We can't say it was the bad influence of the company he kept. However discredited they may be, his colleagues in the NAM are not the types who wilt easily in the bright lights of international

diplomacy. It's not that our prime minister should get a few tips on negotiation from the Mugabes and Ahmadinejads of this world; he should certainly get a crash course on how to strike a fine balance between national interest and international responsibility. His joint statement with the prime minister of Pakistan, issued from the sidelines of the NAM summit, is more than a piece of political naivety. It is a testament of total surrender, and an unsubtle admission that India is negotiable. Take this excerpt: "Prime Minister Gilani mentioned that Pakistan has some information on threats in Balochistan and other areas. Both Prime Ministers recognised that dialogue is the only way forward. Action on terrorism should not be linked to the Composite Dialogue process and these should not be bracketed. Prime Minister Singh said that India was ready to discuss all issues with Pakistan, including all outstanding issues."

A loose translation will read something like

TERROR HAS GEOGRAPHY

too, and the prime minister and the mandarins of South Block can't pretend to be unaware.